

Animals and Society and Sociology



Roasted Lop...

- ...and how I occupy the world
- My place in the world
- And its relation to other people, other animals...

Part 1 – Animals as a problem for Sociology

There are 5 parts to this lecture (too many!!!...)

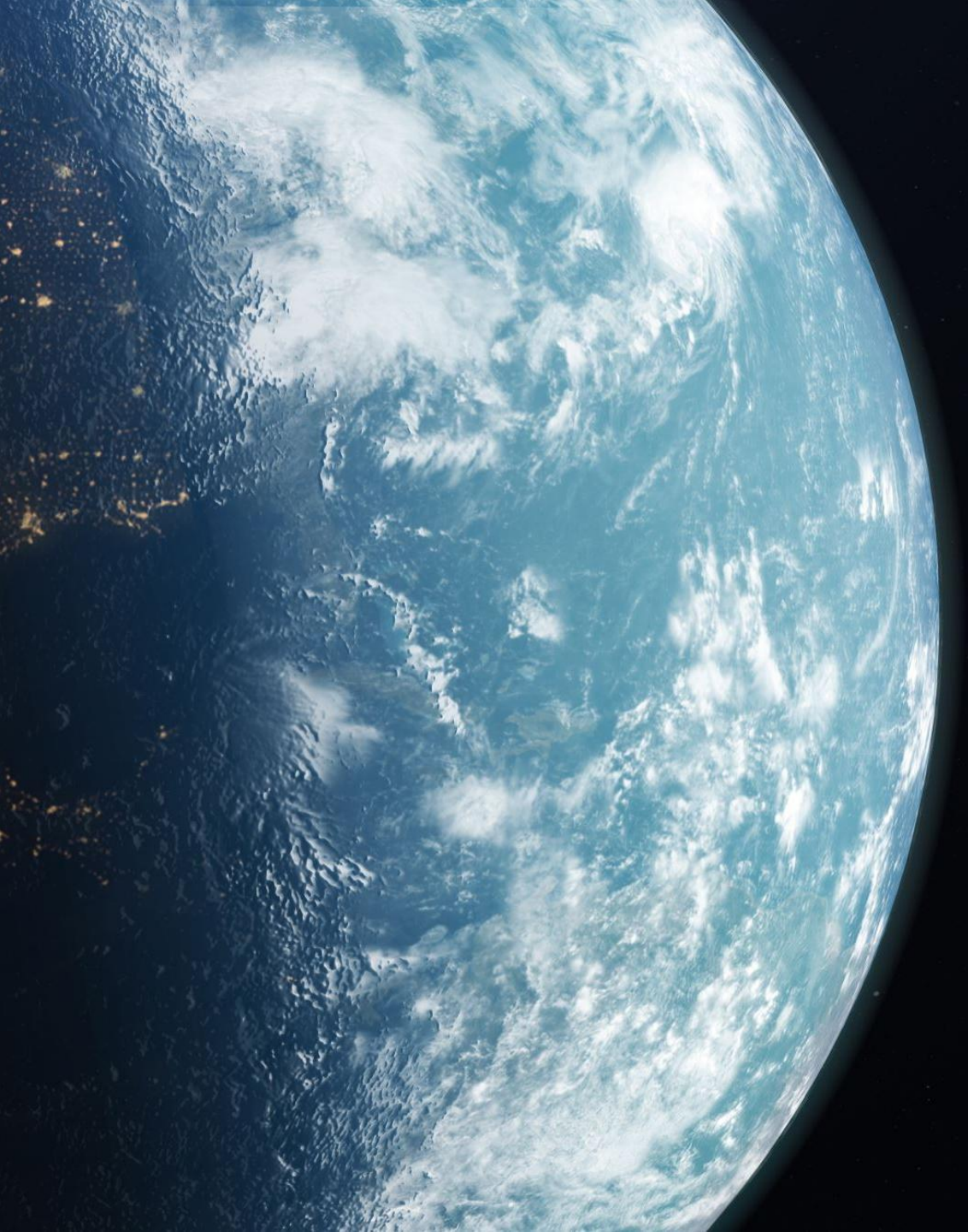
- 1) Animals as a problem for Sociology
- 2) Animals as neglected within modernity
- 3) Developing new ways of thinking
- 4) Other related topics (“should we eat animals?” etc.) which you could follow up in your coursework.
- 5) Extra material which might be useful for your coursework

What is the key point of this lecture?

- In the article which is the key reading for this week, Carter and Charles argue for:
- 'a reconceptualization of society that recognizes that animals are constitutive of it rather than part of a 'nature' with which sociologists are unconcerned ([Tovey, 2003](#)). One of our key claims is that animals are agents entangled in relations with humans and that these relations are frequently ones of domination and exploitation. Our concern therefore is not so much with redefining what a sociological conception of nature might be, but with how a sociological conception of society could encompass human-animal relations.' (Carter and Charles, 2018: 80)

My key “argument” is:

- We need to think about the relations between humans and animals – and perhaps it is only possible for us to be human, and to live in a society, through our relations with animals. The question is how to make these relations “fair”, or at least, not exploitative.
- Some have looked at the symbolic importance of animals (e.g. - pets) but we want to think about “real” animals
- This is quite a task – given that sociology has defined itself as the study of humans and unconcerned with, or opposed to, questions of biology etc.
- (This is the kind of thing I mean when I say I want you to develop an “argument” in your coursework).



“Human Exceptionalism”

- Human exceptionalism is the idea that humans are different to all other animals and entities in the world (and probably in the universe)
- **Humans are exceptions** to the physical or natural laws which supposedly govern biology/nature
- Why?
- Because they (supposedly) have capacities/properties which do not exist elsewhere in the universe
- It is these properties which make “us” human
- We are talking about things like:
 - Intentions – Morality - Symbolism - Consciousness
- This position may seem reasonable at first sight. But it presumes that humans are “above”, “superior” to animals.

Human Exceptionalism and the Chain of Being

This notion of “human exceptionalism” has deep roots.

Some of them are in the Judaeo-Christian outlook on our world and cosmos

One of these is to do with a hierarchy of beings

Going from God at the top

Down to angels

Then Humans

Then animals

Then Elements

Then Inanimate matter



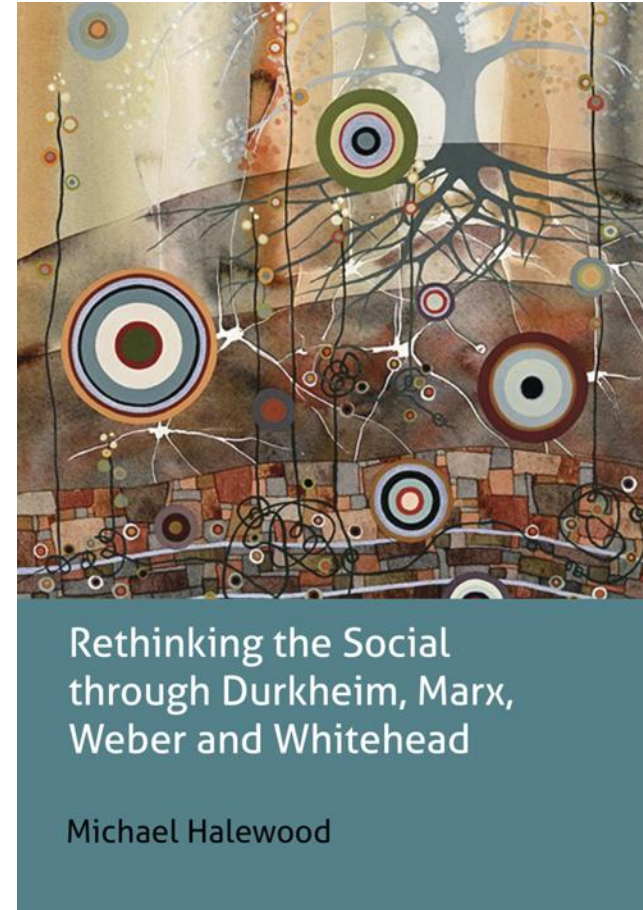
What Has This Got Do With Sociology?

Bifurcation

- Traditional sociology assumes that “humans” and “animals” are two categories that can be clearly distinguished from each other (Carter and Charles, 2011: 2).
- Animals and humans are two completely different entities.
- This represents a bifurcation
- Which matches other ones such as:
- Nature vs Culture
- Genes vs Environment
- Facts vs Values

This is the legacy/influence of a reading of Weber. It links back to the notion of Human Exceptionalism

- Humans have certain abilities and it is these which Sociology should study. These abilities/capacities are:
- Our ability to give meanings to our actions (social action)
- Our ability to take account of the meanings which others give to their actions (empathetic understanding)
- Our capacity to orient our action in relation to certain values (honesty, family, democracy, monarchy, etc.) (value-oriented action)



Meanings, Symbols and Culture

- This (mis)-reading of Weber led to what is sometimes called Interpretivism
- With its emphasis on meanings, on symbols
- On culture (and sub-cultures too)
- The key point (that such a position is based on) is that humans have culture
- Animals do not
- As a result, animals become important as symbols, as bearers of meaning
- For example:
- Pets

“Animal Studies” and Sociology

- The recent rise in interest in branches of sociology and cultural studies of some of the problems involved in making a strict distinction between humans who are assumed to be the only truly “social” entities and animals who only are only allowed a very limited form of sociality, if they are to be granted any at all.
- Back to the key argument of the lecture:
- We need ‘a reconceptualization of society that recognizes that animals are constitutive of it rather than part of a “nature” with which sociologists are unconcerned’ (Carter and Charles, 2018: 80)
- For, is our world (and our society) not full of animals?....

Part 2 – The Neglected Role of Animals in the Modernity

- The 3 key points here are:
- 1) That Modernity (especially in its industrial phase) marked a major shift in our use of, and attitude towards, animals.
- 2) We have forgotten or ignored the role of animals in Sociology.
- 3) That modern societies are only possible because of a whole range of animals (We could not be modern without animals).

Pets



FOOD/FARMING



INSECTS



Power/fuel!

For the next section, we need to use our imagination

We need to rethink/reimagine what the 19th century city was like

Remember that this is what 19th century was concerned with

Understanding/Explaining cities (and modernity)

But did they use all of their senses?

Smell, Hearing, etc....



Re-imagining the city, industrialization and capitalism.

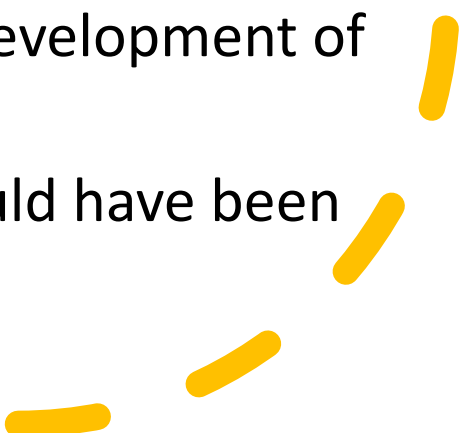
- ‘Horses jammed the streets.... They hauled streetcars, omnibuses, drays, delivery wagons, and private vehicles. Horses delivered raw materials to factories and trucked away the finished products. Horses delivered building materials to construction sites, dug foundations, powered cranes, and hauled away the dirt from excavations...Horses brought produce, dairy products, meat, grain, and hay from surrounding areas into city markets to feed urban consumers and returned stable manure to hinterland farms. Horses conveyed baggage and packages, carried freight to and from railroad depots and shipping piers, distributed coal, milk, ice, bread, and produce, delivered furniture and other consumer goods to homes ...Horses provided virtually all the power for the internal circulation of city life because no other prime mover could compete with them technologically.’ (Greene, 2008: 170)

But we get no sense of this in Marx and Engel’s *Communist Manifesto* or other books on industrialization.

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- ‘The average horse produced twenty to fifty pounds of manure and a gallon of urine daily, distributed freely between stables and streets. With 131,000 horses in New York City by 1900, the result was 1,300–3,300 tons of horse manure daily in the city as a whole, or 5–12 tons per square mile given a horse density of 486. The carcasses of horses that died in the streets often lay for several days before being removed’ (Greene, 2008: 174)

Because horses were so central to the development of the modern city they went “unseen”.

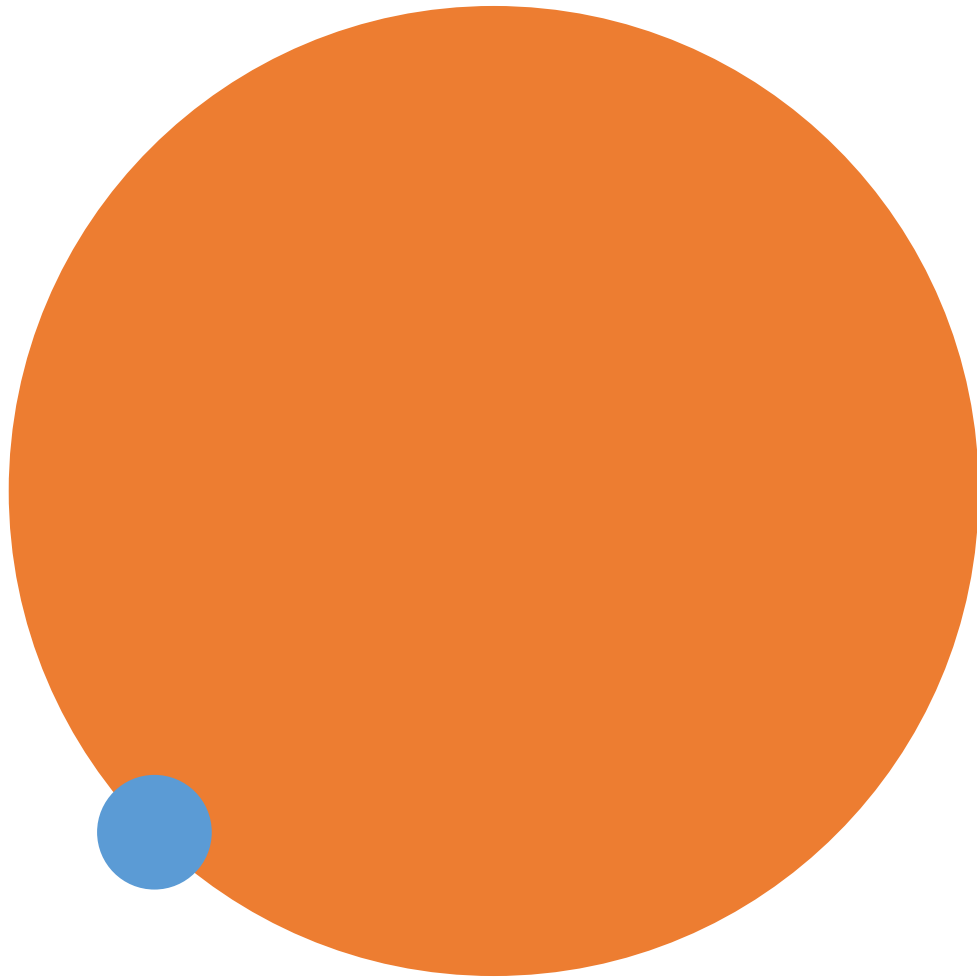
They were not thought about as life would have been unthinkable without them.



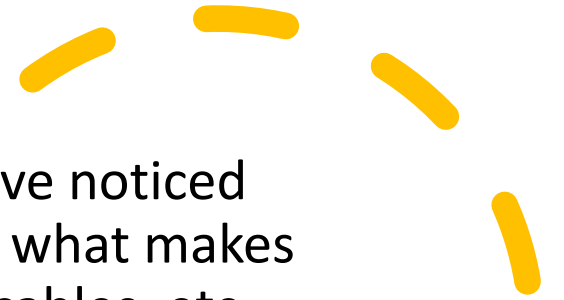
Modernity/Industrialization and Animals



- It is not too strong to argue that without animals we would not have had industrialisation and hence modernity and the modern societies we live in now:
- Horses and horse-power
- Greene (2008: 4) on horses as “living machines”
- War-horse, race-horse, plough horse, pit ponies, etc.
- There are not that many photos of horses in the 19th century because they wouldn't stay still! And many photos were taken on a Sunday (day of rest) because the streets were quieter.



- People would, perhaps, not have noticed horses, just as we don't notice what makes our society tick – the internet cables, etc.
- And making the familiar strange is one of the main roles of sociology.
- That is what we need to do.
- And to think about;
- 1) Why we forgot about horses
- 2) What other roles animals play in our society...



Back to
Carter and
Charles:
A bit like the
“rise” of
feminism?

- 4 stages:
- Pre-feminist era – women not the focus of sociological research, except in the “family”
- A critique of the neglect of analysis of women in sociology/society
- The attempt to “add women in” to sociological analyses
- The full integration of gender into sociology (as you see in SC 301)
- Where are we up to with animals?

Part 3 – Developing New Ways of Thinking

Companion Species

- We are not alone
- Donna Haraway on “Companion Species”
- It is not an “either/or”
- It is not that there are Humans on the one side **AND** animals on the other
- Humans become humans through their relations with animals
- Co-evolution
- “Being-with”
- An attempt to develop new ways of thinking about our relations with animals which avoids bifurcations
- “Thumper”

- *Haraway, Donna Jeanne. (2003). The companion species manifesto : dogs, people, and significant otherness. Chicago, Ill. : Bristol :Prickly Paradigm*



“Thumper”



Dr Alexandra Kimbo

- Studied this module about 10 years ago
- Then researched a PhD with the title:
- Sociology, Sociality and Animals: Beyond the social/natural divide
- Here are some of her ideas:
- “How to think (theorise/conceptualise) *with* (and for) other animals, as opposed to *about* them”
- “How to take into account what *matters* for nonhuman animals?”
- “How do we ensure that we are “asking the right questions””

Thinking with her companion (dog) Harald

- “Harald and I may express love differently, and each have unique perspectives, but the possibility of loving exists nonetheless. Thus, regardless of how “different” individuals are from each other, experience can still be *shared*. “
- “If two individual bodies (or centres of experiences and flows of feeling) open themselves up or attune to each other, thus feeling-for mutual possibilities, shared experience is what matters foremost.”

What is at stake?

- Do animals threaten our conceptions of ourselves?
- That is to say, once we start thinking about animals, we become unsure of who and what we really are?
- More imagination:
- What would sociology be like if we started from the position that we are just one kind of animal among others?

Some people (and sociologists) want to retain an element of human exceptionalism

- They argue that only humans have language
- And that only humans have culture
- (This argument is to be found not just in symbolic interactionism and sociologists such as Mead and Goffman, but also in the work of writers such as Roland Barthes, Saussure and Baudrillard.)
- Some people want to argue the opposite, namely:
 - That animals can communicate (though they don't obviously have human language)
 - That animals have culture
 - Even that animals have consciousness and agency
 - And should be given rights
- A New York lawyer went to court to try to get two chimpanzees awarded "personhood"
- <https://www.nbcnews.com/news/us-news/do-apes-deserve-personhood-rights-lawyer-heads-n-y-supreme-n731431>

- My feeling is that we probably can't answer these questions in the terms that they are framed.
- What do I mean by this?
- The question of rights/language/culture invoke a bifurcation
- Perhaps we should turn these questions round.
- Why don't we want animals to have agency, subjectivity, the ability to use symbols?
- Why do we want to keep culture to ourselves?
- Why do we want to keep rights to ourselves?
- Do animals have souls? (I am trying to write about this with my ex-PhD student)

Part 4 – Other related topics which you might follow up in your coursework

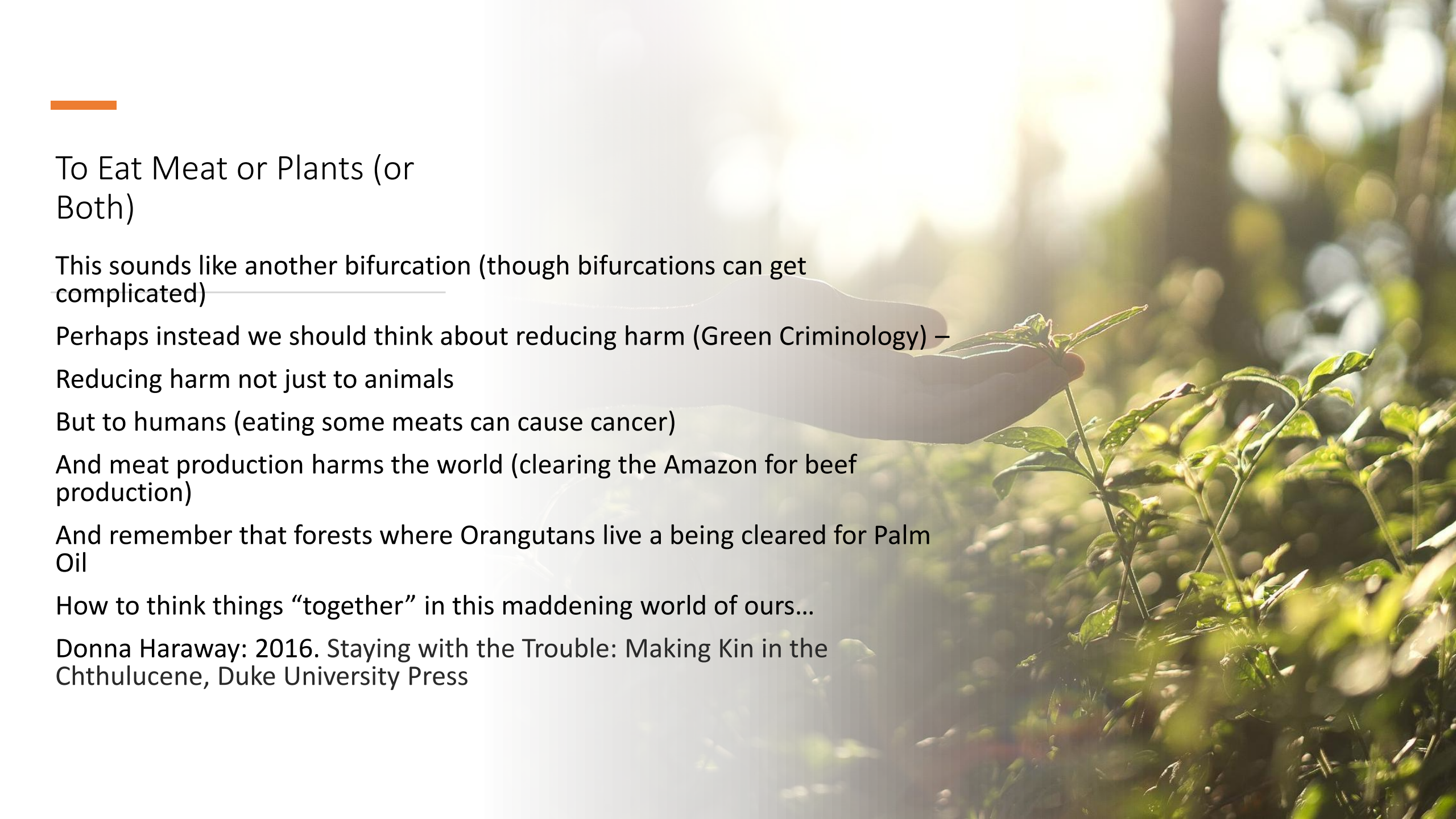
-But only once you have discussed/analysed/explained the Carter and Charles article.

Should we eat animals?

We need to consume something in order to produce and consume.

- **Veganism**
- 3 approaches (see Greenebaum, 2012):
- Health vegans (lose weight/improve health)
- Environmental Vegans (impact of industrial/intensive farming – but may buy leather rather than plastic)
- Ethical Vegans (moral/political views)



A hand holding a small green plant against a sunlit forest background.

To Eat Meat or Plants (or Both)

This sounds like another bifurcation (though bifurcations can get complicated)

Perhaps instead we should think about reducing harm (Green Criminology) –

Reducing harm not just to animals

But to humans (eating some meats can cause cancer)

And meat production harms the world (clearing the Amazon for beef production)

And remember that forests where Orangutans live are being cleared for Palm Oil

How to think things “together” in this maddening world of ours...

Donna Haraway: 2016. *Staying with the Trouble: Making Kin in the Chthulucene*, Duke University Press

The next 3 slides were from an old version of this lecture

- I will not read them out
- But I have left them in, because they might be useful if you are doing an essay on this topic.

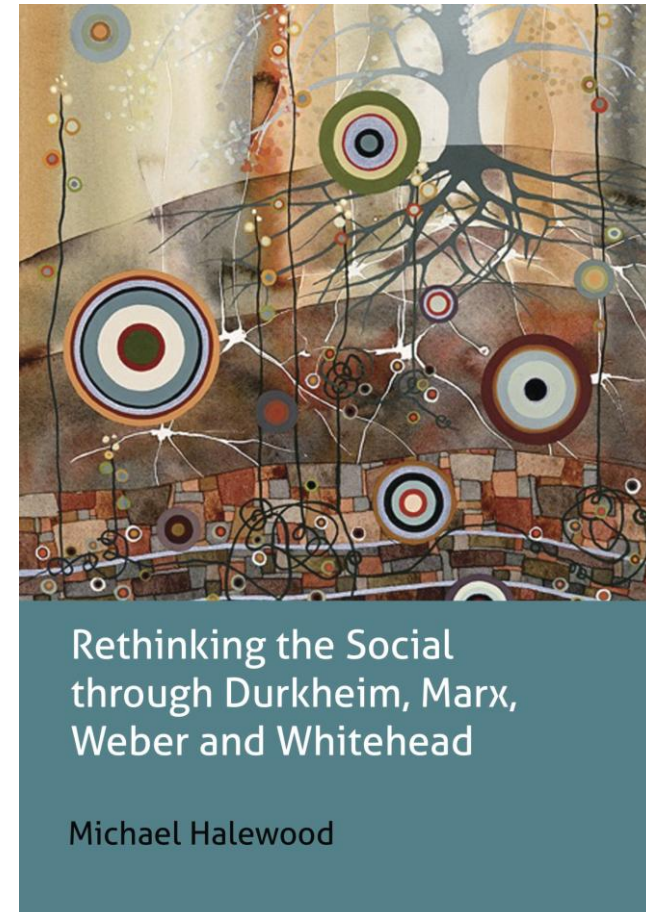
Part 5 – Extra stuff which might be useful for your coursework....

Where are the animals in Sociology?

- They are “there” at the start, but only on the side-lines...
- Durkheim:
- ‘It has not even been proved at all that the tendency to sociability was originally a congenital instinct of the human race’. (Rules of Sociological Method: 132)
- It is much more natural to see in it [sociability] a product of social life which has slowly become organised in us’ (Rules of Sociological Method: 132)
- ‘it is an observable fact that animals are sociable or otherwise, depending on whether their environmental conditions force them to live in common or cause them to shun such a life’. (Rules of Sociological Method: 132)

Weber

- ‘many animals “understand” [“verstehen”] commands, anger, love, hostility and react to them in ways which are evidently often by no means purely instinctive and mechanical and in some sense both consciously meaningful [sinnhaft] and affected by experience’ (Economy and Society: 15–16; W&G, 7).
- ‘A verifiable conception of the state of mind of these social animals [sozialen Tiernindividuen] accessible to meaningful understanding [sinnhaften “Verstehens”] of the world, would seem to be attainable even as an ideal goal only within narrow limits.’ (Economy and Society: 17; W&G, 8)



So where did the animals go? Why did we stop thinking about them?

- I blame Talcott Parsons!
- For most of the 20th century, sociologists (influenced by Parsons) seem to assume and insist that whatever sociality is, it is a production of humans, groups or humans or systems of humans.
- Animals were rarely, if ever, considered.
- To ascribe genuine sociality to animals would seem to threaten the grounding and specificity of the social, which should, it is claimed, be restricted to the human realm alone.